

Just Ask Mandy

A customer story. Deadpan testimonial, filmed at a fourteen-room seafront hotel on the Essex coast and on a beach in Spain, February to August 2028. Two minutes.

The principle. Mandy is the duty manager of a seafront hotel, and her job is four things: the handover, the phone, the money and the desk. After one day off went wrong, she wanted it not to matter if she wasn't in. She had never made anything in her life, but she asked Code Overlord for an app to do the handover, had Just Ask Mandy working by teatime, and because it worked she kept going back and handing it the next thing, until it was doing all four in her voice. It mattered so little whether she was in that she went to Spain.

Why it is funny. Every piece of her job she gives away is done perfectly, in her own voice, so the less she is there, the more everybody thinks she is. She never once finds this odd, and it takes a very long time for anybody else to.

On screen: SOUTHEND-ON-SEA, FEBRUARY 2028.

In February, Mandy took her first Tuesday off in four years.

"Room seven asked for a cot. I wasn't in. The baby slept in a drawer."

On the pad, in three people's handwriting: JUST ASK MANDY.

"What's your job?"

"Four things. The handover, the phone, the money and the desk."

"And what did you want?"

"For it not to matter if I wasn't in."

She had never made anything. She typed one sentence into Code Overlord: "Do the handover properly. Don't miss anything out." She called it what the pad says.

By teatime the whole day is on a screen in the back office. Across the top: JUST ASK MANDY.

"That's the handover."

Then she asked Code Overlord for the phone, in her voice. It does the wake-up calls.

"Karen on nights thought I was in." A pause. "I was asleep." A pause. "That's the phone."

Then the card machine. Mr Ashworth has checked out at five for nine years, so he never has to speak to anybody. Now, at five, in her voice: "That's you settled, Mr Ashworth."

"He started leaving at four. It's up at four." A pause. "He's on half three now. That's the money."

In May she asked Code Overlord for the desk: a speaker, the bell, and justaskmandy.com on a little screen.

"What does it say when somebody rings?"

"What I say."

"So what's left?"

"Nothing."

In June, Mandy went to Spain. She told nobody. It didn't matter if she wasn't in.

Her sister went round every Sunday. Nobody in. She rang the hotel.

"Sorry, darling, I'm just out the back."

In August she reported Mandy missing. A policeman. Ding.

"Sorry, darling, I'm just out the back."

"I'm looking for Mandy."

"Speaking."

He writes down: found safe and well.

Two undertakers, with a trolley. Ding.

"Sorry, darling, I'm just out the back. What can I do for you?"

"We've come for Mr Ashworth."

"Lift's on the left. He's paid up till Thursday."

A woman from room eight, in labour. Ding.

"Sorry, darling, I'm just out the back. Lie down on the settee and breathe when I say."

Eleven minutes later the midwife comes in. There is a baby on the settee.

"Who delivered this?"

"Mandy."

"Where is she?"

"Sorry, darling, I'm just out the back."

"Then get out here!"

[CONTINUOUS BLEEP]

A pause. "Do you want a cot? It's ten pound a night."

Clive, the owner, has not seen Mandy since June. Ding.

"Sorry, Clive, I'm just out the back."

"I've been out the back."

"Further back, Clive."

Shoeburyness. A bus stop. Dark. His phone rings.

"Is this far enough?"

"Bit further, Clive."

A pause. "You're not her, are you."

"Sorry, Clive, I'm just out the back."

"[BLEEP] off."

"Night, Clive. Mind how you go."

A beach in Spain. Mandy, on a lounge, with a cocktail.

"Are you on shift?"

"Seven till seven."

At half seven her phone reads her the handover.

"Mr Ashworth, collected. Room eight, a girl. Mandy, found safe and well."

"Would you recommend Code Overlord?"

"Yes." A pause. "Clive's in Shoeburyness."

She has a sip. Card. Nothing after it.

What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does. One plain sentence typed into the composer, and a session starting on the day's notes. A schedule called Handover, running morning and evening, the instruction she typed still showing, still arriving on her phone in Spain. Her app wired into everything it touches, one ask at a time: the phone number, the card machine, the bell. The laptop is shut in the desk drawer in Southend, and it keeps running.

Accent. The whole cast is Southend, Essex, Mandy included, and Just Ask Mandy speaks in exactly the same accent because it is her voice. Mandy is in her late fifties, ordinary and sincere, never glamorous and never groomed. The accent lives in the grammar and the words, never in the spelling: "seven till seven", "ten pound", "darling", "they never said", "mind how you go". Cast and voice it that way without exception.

How this was made. The first version went through five rate-and-rewrite rounds with an independent reader, 22, 26, 30, 30, 34 out of forty. It was rebuilt around his note, her handing over one piece of her job at a time until the desk answers every guest in her voice, and put through the comedians' panel twice: Tim Robinson, Jimmy Carr, Diane Morgan, Victoria Wood and Nathan Fielder. All five said the rebuild was funnier, and three said its peaks beat Taking Back Tuesday's. It was then given a spine he can hold, her job as four things handed over one at a time until she goes to Spain, and condensed to two minutes around the best gags. On his last note the lead was recast: Mandy, an Essex duty manager in her late fifties, the app named Just Ask Mandy, and the last image a lounge and a cocktail. The long version is kept beside it as the gag bank.

Three things to decide. The ending: "Yes." / "Clive's in Shoeburyness.", recommended, a clean yes to the product with the fact after it, over "They ask me." The order: her sister and the policeman first, recommended, because she told nobody, so her sister is the first to notice, then the guests at the desk, over the undertakers straight after she leaves. The cot: "It's ten pound a night", recommended, a charge a real hotel makes, and the cot that failed in February arriving without her.